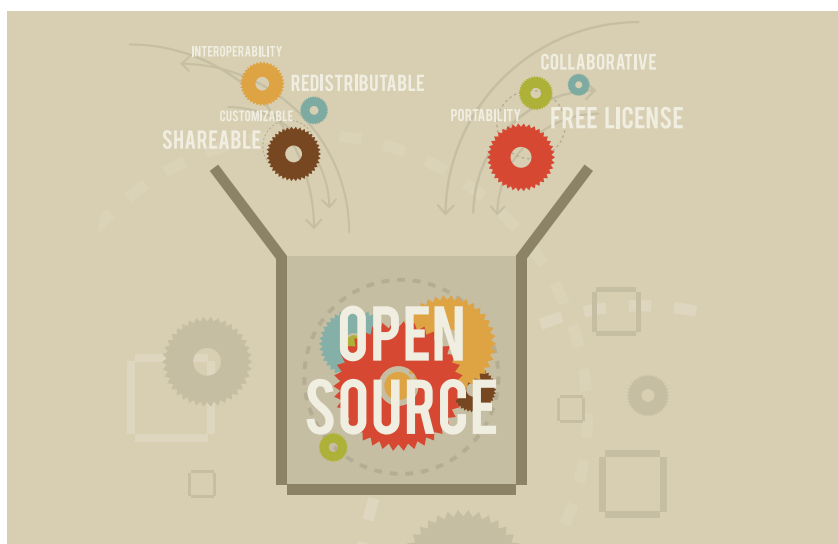


Why Companies Need to Set Up an Open Source Program Office

Managing the use of open source software and decreasing compliance risks is key to the success of any software product. An open source program office can help an organisation do just that. Find out how.



Open source software (OSS) is integral to building a modern software solution. Be it an internal or a customer facing solution, organisations rely significantly on open source software today. OSS components are governed by their unique licence terms, and non-compliance with these can often expose organisations to security and intellectual property (IP) risks which eventually may hamper a company's brand value.

When development teams are delivering a software release, they are primarily trying to meet project deadlines. Therefore, the tracking of versions of components and libraries, or the third party code pulled into the project, is not as rigorous as it should be. This means that licences and vulnerable OSS components can

enter the code base and be delivered to customers. This can be risky for both the customer and the company delivering the software solution.

Another increasingly challenging area is that of developers contributing to open source projects. Companies can reap numerous benefits if they do so. This includes keeping skills current, retention of staff, attracting developers to work for the organisation, and improving the image of the company. Many open source projects require developers to sign a contributor licence agreement. This states that any IP created by the developer belongs to the project and not to the contributing developer. In this scenario, organisations need to be careful that IP and trade secrets that are not open source are not being signed over to open source projects.

Developers need to be educated about open source licensing issues, determining what to leverage, when or how much they can contribute to the community, and what packages might bring risk to the organisation's reputation. All this can be streamlined by putting a strategic policy and operations in place. One way of doing this is by creating an entity that is dedicated to working around all things open source—an entity called the open source program office (OSPO).

An OSPO creates an ecosystem for employees to use open source software in a way that compliance risks are kept at bay. The role of an OSPO is not limited to supervising open source usage; it is also responsible for contributing back to the community and managing the company's growth in the market by actively engaging in events, as well as conducting webinars and campaigns.

In this article we will see why there is a need for building an OSPO, and how it has emerged as a prominent entity for any open source policy and governance programme.

Why should you have an OSPO?

With the wide use of open source software, regulating its usage and keeping the compliance strategy in check can be often overwhelming for the teams involved in the product development cycle.

Developers often overlook licence obligations, and sometimes the management or stakeholders are also not fully aware of the implications of